

SCENE 1: INTRODUCTION

FADE IN

EXT. WHITE PICKET FENCE LAWN - DAY

Open with credit scenes and fun animations with Rye's rough hands as he mows different lawns of Huntington Beach neighborhoods.

INT. NAIL SALON - DAY

Juxtaposed to back and forth scenes of what seems like a dainty hand being painted. Swanky, upbeat, salon music.

CREDITS END

EXT. EVENT VENUE - DAY

RYE [18, Vietnamese] narrates from behind a podium while wearing a graduation cap.

RYE (O.S.)
For those of you here who don't
know,

INT. NAIL SALON - DAY

A small eye opens on the other side of a tacky rectangular fish tank of a nail salon. We're looking through as the eye follows the fish back and forth.

RYE (V.O.)
Vietnamese is a monosyllabic
language.

Young Rye suddenly digs his hand in the tank to snatch a fish before commotion ensues to stop him.

EXT. VIETNAMESE SCHOOL - DAY

Scene cuts to him at a foldout table desk sitting beside other Vietnamese kids, slightly older.

RYE (V.O.)
There are 6 distinct tones: ṣc,
huỵn, ṇng, ḥi, ngā, and ngang.

Animation as he explains each of them, like cartoons with onomatopoeias popping out for each.

Rye is attempting to focus but looks lost.

RYE (V.O.)
It is very direct and
straightforward-but one cannot
reduce them to just sounds, they're
feelings carried through the mouth.

He raises his hand.

RYE (V.O.)
Hỏi means to ask, so, yes, the tone
you use like a question.

Rye's lips start moving without the voiceover.

His classmates turn around dramatically and stare at him like he's braindead.

EXT. BASKETBALL COURT - DAY

Montage of Rye playing basketball outside with his friends, slightly older again. He goes for a jumpshot. His aim is terrible, but he's a big boy and can do some damage by plowing through everyone else and snatching the ball.

RYE (V.O.)
Nặng means heavy, so you pronounce
the word like you've been grasping
a heavy boulder and that syllable
is the moment you can relieve
yourself of carrying it.

He makes a layup while other smaller kids are simply afraid of getting close to him. He thinks he's good at the game.

INT. NAIL SALON - DAY

The eye is older and Rye stands behind the tank, now 18 years old, still tracking the fish back and forth.

CAMERA FOLLOWS HIM UP AS HE STANDS COMPLETELY UPRIGHT AND WALKS TO THE RIGHT, HANDHELD PAN TO HIM WALKING OVER TO SIT ON A STOOL BESIDE HIS MOM AS SHE WORKS ON THE ORIGINAL SET OF NAILS WE SAW IN THE INTRO.

RYE (O.S.)
In Vietnamese, we have two words
for love: yeu and thuong.

SCENE 2: LIFE WITH NANCY AND RYE

INT. NAIL SALON - DAY

NANCY [Mid 30s, glamorous] is working on nails of CLIENT [White, Valley Girl Accent] and chattering with an accent that tells you she's Vietnamese before she does.

NANCY

Honey, you want the gel nail or the acrylic?

Rye rolls his eyes from his stool.

NANCY KICKS HIS FOOT UNDER THE DESK.

Rye continues scrolling on his phone until she's done.

NANCY (CONT'D)

Okay, honey, you done. You want the Apple Pay again or you have cash this time?

Rye is now doing some homework but watching their whole interaction.

CLIENT (CHEWING GUM)

Apple Pay. Thank youu~

Client leaves and Nancy sits back down.

RYE

Ma oi, why do you always have to do that dumb accent thing?

NANCY (WITH REAL VOICE)

Why you always in my business?

RYE

It's weird, ma.

NANCY

I get more tips that way.

RYE

You only do it on white people...

NANCY (IN FAKE ACCENT)

They like it, honey.

Rye rolls his eyes again.

NANCY (CONT'D)
Stop doing that, boy. It's disrespectful.

RYE
Da. I'm going to work now.

NANCY
Ok. You finish your homework? Who today?

RYE
Cierra down the street again.

NANCY
Homework?

RYE
Yeah, mostly.

NANCY
Imma smack you up if you lie to me again.

RYE
Ok, mom. Should I come back after or will you be home?

NANCY
I'll be here. Make sure to give her a hug. Maybe she'll tip you more.

RYE
That's messed up, Ma. Bye. Love you.

SCENE 3: LANDSCAPING

EXT. WHITE PICKET FENCE LAWN - EVENING

Rye wears headphones. He's enjoying himself as he clips the shrubbery and mows the lawn while the sun sets.

Rye rings CIERRA'S [Old, petite, hard of hearing] doorbell.

RYE
Hi, Ms. Cierra. I'm done with your yard.

CIERRA
Thank you, sweetheart.

Cierra gives him a hug then looks around in admiration. There's a shrub that's been cut to look like a bunny.

CIERRA (CONT'D)
It's perfect, as always.

Cierra hugs him. She takes out her wallet and shakily hands him two hundreds.

RYE
Oh, I can't take this.

CIERRA
Where else will my money go, dear?
I'm old. I can't hear much. A
pretty sight in my yard means twice
as much as a pretty song.

Rye reluctantly takes the bills.

RYE
Thank you, Ms. Cierra.

CIERRA
Yes. Come back sooner than later.

On his way out, Rye takes a ribbon from his pocket and ties it around an ear of the shrub bunny.

SCENE 4: DANIEL ENTERS

The salon bell rings as Rye enters. Sitting in the stool beside Nancy is DANIEL [Early 40s, Black American], her boyfriend but not fiancé. You would expect him to have glasses with a strong prescription. Rye daps him up and side-hugs Nancy.

DANIEL
Hey, Rye Guy. How was work?

RYE
Not too bad. Two yards today.

NANCY
Only two yards? How you get paid
then?

DANIEL
That means two hundred, Nan. He did
well today.

NANCY

Why you still call me that? You make me sound like someone's grandma.

RYE

Alright, Nan. Let's go home.

NANCY

That's Ma to you, boy.

DANIEL

Play nice, you two. Family.

NANCY

Tell him to treat his mother with some respect.

RYE

Tell her to take a joke if she's always making them!

DANIEL

That's enough.

Daniel takes out his keys and Nancy locks up shop behind him.

SCENE 5: HOME LIFE

EXT. SHITTY APARTMENT - NIGHT

Unsafe area. Rye out the car first. Runs to barred entrance. Nancy swipes key out of ignition, tosses it out of window into Rye's hand. He holds open the entrance door as Nancy gets out the car and runs in. A streamlined, seamless routine to enter as quickly as possible, a secret handshake.

Elevator is broken so they sprint up the stairs. Nancy lags behind and begins coughing at the top.

RYE

Ma, can you go any slower?

NANCY

Can you be any more annoying?

They enter their rundown apartment with a broken lock. A nightstand with two jars. One has a taped note that says "College" and one says "House."

RYE DROPS HIS TWO HUNDREDS INTO HOUSE JAR. NANCY FOLLOWS BEHIND AND MOVES BOTH BILLS INTO COLLEGE.

Rye goes to the fridge and the lights are off.

RYE
Ma, electricity is out again.

Nancy is already sprawled on the couch with a face mask on. Half a bottle of Hennessy is on the table.

NANCY
Con biet lam gi, ma.
Subtitles: You know what to do.

Rye groans and walks over to the generator and smacks it. Once. Beat. Twice. Beat. He loses his patience—three sudden and aggressive bangs. The lights turn back on.

RYE
Did you look at any houses with Daniel?

NANCY
I'll get to it after next week.

RYE
Ma, please. You keep saying that. I can't live here anymore.

NANCY
Okay, did you do any college applications?

RYE
Yes.

NANCY
Liar. You are a liar. To your own mother.

RYE
I did.

NANCY
To where?

RYE
Cascadia.

NANCY
Community? Are you serious? You think I left by boat for you to go to community?

RYE

It's just in case. I'm not going anywhere good.

NANCY

Are you even trying?

RYE

Yes. I am. I am always trying.

NANCY

Then why do I have to keep asking you this?

RYE

Then stop nagging me!

NANCY

Then you're going to end up like me. Young and pregnant and no money. Ever. And it won't be my fault.

Rye clomps to his room, moving two bills from College to House and knocking the jars together. Nancy is still on the couch relaxing, now eyes closed. She lets out a cough and takes a pill from her pocket, washing it down with the Hennessy.

SCENE 6: RYE SCHOOL

EXT. SCHOOL PARKING LOT - DAY

Rye rolls into the lot in his dingy landscaping truck. Rubbing sleep from his eyes, music playing. He parks and leans over a fence to the field where the football players are practicing.

LILY [18, cute, preppy] springs up and rests her head onto her shoulder. She's wearing a cardigan that you know isn't polyester.

LILY

Daydreaming again?

RYE

Just enjoying my morning view.

LILY

What about this morning view?

Lily turns his cheek towards her and gives him a kiss.

RYE
That works, too.

LILY
Just works? God, I should really go
where I'm appreciated, huh?

RYE
I'm sorry. Just tired.

LILY
It's okay. You always are.

Beat.

LILY (CONT'D)
Let's go to class. I brought you a
cake pop.

RYE
Thank you, Lily Billy.

He kisses her cheek.

SCENE 7: DARK ACADEMIA

INT. CLASSROOM - DAY

TEACHER stands with arms crossed, gazing at watch.

Rye is writing frantically, brows furrowed.

TEACHER
Times up! Pencils down.

Lily neatly wipes eraser shavings off her page.

Rye peers over and quickly copies off her.

RYE
Fuck. Fuckkkk....

SCENE 8: DEBRIEF

INT. HALLWAY - DAY

LILY
What'd you think?

RYE

Not enough apparently. I didn't finish again.

LILY

You didn't study, Rye?

RYE

Lil, your two hours of studying is worth five of mine. It's like, exponential.

LILY

Oh, Rye. If you talk like that, of course you don't believe in yourself.

RYE

I don't care anymore, honestly. It's a lost cause.

LILY

Yeah, with that non-growth mentality.

RYE

You sound like a PE teacher talking to the fat kid.

Lily smacks his arm as he stops at a door.

RYE (CONT'D)

Bye. Gotta make a visit.

LILY

Not eating lunch with me again?

RYE

Enjoy your croquette club or whatever rich people do.

LILY

How many times do I have to tell you croquette is a potato?

LILY (CONT'D)

And don't forget about dinner tonight.

RYE (UNDER BREATH)

Fuck...

SCENE 9: LUNCH BREAK

INT. DANIEL'S CLASSROOM - DAY

RYE
Hey, Big D.

DANIEL
What'd I say about that name on
school grounds, Rye?

RYE
Uh, probably the same thing you
said at home.

DANIEL
Which was?

RYE
It's not that big.

Daniel sighs.

DANIEL
Alright, Rye Guy. Let's open that
document.

RYE
Aw, come on, D-Boy! Can you never
just hang out with me?

DANIEL
Was it not hanging out when we
watched the entirety of the Lakers
game together?

RYE
No more LeBron. It's like watching
an old video of your dead wife.

Daniel shakes his head and tries to not laugh.

DANIEL
Please just open it.

RYE
Fine.

He moves deliberately slow.

DANIEL
Lunch is only 30 minutes. Is there
something you want to say?

RYE

And what if I told you I was trying to use up 29 minutes because I haven't written anything since last time?

Daniel sighs again.

DANIEL

Why don't you want to do this?

RYE

Who said I don't? I get busy, I get tired. It's nothing.

DANIEL

No. I work with hundreds of you. I can tell when someone is just tired.

RYE

It's nothing. It's stupid.

DANIEL

What is? Your reason, or college?

RYE

Both! What, you practically write my essay for me, then I go to college and I'm just dumber than everyone else? Small fish begging to join a big pond?

DANIEL

Confucius once said—"When frying small fish, disturb them little."

RYE

See? I don't want to learn bullshit like that. I don't want to learn, period. Mom wants me to. But not because I want to. Because she didn't get to.

DANIEL

Do you really feel that way?

RYE

Yes, always.

DANIEL

She just wants what's best for you. You know that, don't you?

RYE

And how does she know what's best?

Beat.

RYE (CONT'D)

I'm big. I know that. I'm strong. I know that. But that doesn't mean I'm smart. Why is that so bad?

DANIEL

You're smarter than you know... and these schools don't want perfection. They want coachability, they want growth.

RYE

Well, unfortunately, I don't get to be a "coachable" football player either. I mow lawns and I get by. I know what I am and I'm not ashamed.

DANIEL

Okay, Rye. If you won't do it for you, or your mom, will you do some writing? For me?

RYE

Oh, don't pull this card on me.

DANIEL

It's not a card. I'm a teacher. I need a refreshing perspective now and then. Write about you.

Rye hesitates.

DANIEL (CONT'D)

Think about how many nerds I have to read essays for.

Beat.

Tell me about a favorite childhood memory of yours that I wouldn't know about.

SCENE 10: CHILDHOOD FLASHBACK SEQUENCE

INT. NAIL SALON - DAY

Montage of Rye's childhood routine.

RYE (V.O.)
I grew up in that salon with the
marble floors and sticker tiles.

Rye playing with toy trucks across salon floor.

RYE (V.O.)
They were nicer than the apartment,
so I went there every day after
school and played on the chairs.

Energetic, bouncing around different parts of the salon,
sticky silicone-cased iPad with him.

RYE (V.O.)
My mom never got to sit by those
ladies. She was always massaging
their feet.

Younger Nancy giving pedicure. Wearing a button-up shirt but
with flip flops and capris.

RYE (V.O.)
But she always said that, if I felt
bad for her, I was telling her she
should be embarrassed.

RYE (V.O.)
But I think deep down, she was
always ashamed.

Rye looks up from iPad. It's dark out now, Nancy is counting
bills at the register.

RYE (V.O.)
But what she didn't know was that I
didn't really care because when
that My Trang lady came in, she
would always soak the rhinestones
off in the foot bath.

Back to Nancy giving pedicure to RHINESTONE LADY [White, also
glamorous] with white puppy in her arms.

Nancy finishes and presses a button to drain the basin. Rye
watches them go to the register, then kneels beside the
chair, grabbing rhinestones and putting them in his pocket.

RYE (V.O.)
And while she wasn't looking, I
would keep those rhinestones for
myself and feed them to the fish
like food.

Him dropping stones in the tank.

RYE (V.O.)
And I would always get sad when
those fish died, so Ma would take
me to get a McFlurry.

Sitting back with his iPad in one hand, ice cream in the
other.

RYE (V.O.)
So, I guess. I just kept killing
the fish which made me sad but then
I got ice cream which made me
happy.

FADE INTO RYE SITTING IN THE SAME STOOL WITH A LAPTOP
(PRESENT)

SCENE 11: NAIL ROUTINE

INT. NAIL SALON - DAY

Rye comes through the door. Nancy is painting nails of CLIENT
2.

RYE
ICE here to deport Nancy!

NANCY
Nancy here to whoop Rye's butt.

The two laugh. Rye is holding a baggy. Nancy stays focused
but pauses to let out a cough.

RYE
Daniel bought you some banh mi. I
ate most of it already.

NANCY
Thank you, con.

RYE
I worked on the essay today, too.

Nancy finally turns.

NANCY
Con gioi!
Subtitles: Oh, good son!
What did you write about?

RYE

How I used to kill the fish and you
would take me to get McFlurries
after.

NANCY

Con co dien khong?
Subtitles: Are you crazy?

NANCY (CONT'D)

They're going to think you a serial
killer!

RYE

Well. At least I wrote. Let's see
what Daniel says.

Nancy rubs her eyebrows and goes back to work, but continues
coughing.

NANCY

Someday, I am going to be... old,
like 40, and I am going to have
gray hairs on my whole head while
het nguoi ta
Subtitles: everyone else
have 2 or 3. Because you stress me
out.

Nancy puts down the nail drill and begins gesticulating.

RYE

Oh, ma—

NANCY

No, I am going to be wrinkled—giong
nhu ba nay day
Subtitles: like this old lady here

Nancy pauses from doing nails and looks in the mirror. Client
2 clearly wants to be included.

NANCY (CONT'D)

Or like chestnut, or mot hòn dái!
Subtitles: or a ballsack!

NANCY (CONT'D)

Because of you!

RYE

You're so dramatic. You're the only
one that will care about how you
look when you're 40.

CLIENT 2

It's true, honey. I thought I was gonna die alone after my husband cheated on me with our housekeeper. But trust me, these younger men LOVE an experienced woman. Seasoned, if you will, just the other day—

Rye and Nancy make awkward eye contact. Nancy starts coughing to silence the oversharer, who keeps talking. Nancy coughs louder, tongue out.

RYE

I'm gonna go now... Two lawns today.

He looks over hoping for some reassurance. Crickets.

RYE (CONT'D)

Also, why are you coughing so much? Do I need to pick up medicine?

NANCY

No. Bye, con. Food in the fridge at home. And don't write anymore bullshit.

Rye leaves.

SCENE 12: THE DISCOVERY

INT. SHITTY APARTMENT - DAY

Rye is looking in the mirror, adjusting his shirt to hide a stain and shaving his stubble.

He grabs deodorant from the mirror cabinet and finds a pill jar with a bunch of words he doesn't know. He inspects briefly, then pockets it.

SCENE 13: DINNER AT LILY'S

EXT. BEAUTIFUL HOME - EVENING

Rye rings the doorbell with a grocery store bouquet in hand. Lily opens the door excitedly and embraces him.

LILY

You know you don't have to!

RYE
Yes, I'm just the best boyfriend
ever.

LILY
Come in.

INT. BEAUTIFUL LIVING ROOM - EVENING

Rye enters and we take in all the surroundings with him while Lily takes the flowers and puts them in a fancy vase. Fancy paintings, gold accents, and ornate dolls. Rye picks one up and plays with it in his hands.

RYE
These are creepy as hell.

LILY
My parents. Collectibles. Worth a
lot, you know. It's like the
weirder the shape, the more it
costs.

RYE
Can I talk to your mom about
something?

LILY
Yeah, what is it?

RYE
I found this. And my mom's been
coughing.

He hands over the pill container.

LILY
Oh. I mean, it could be like how
people take Ozempic without being
diabetic. For aesthetics?

RYE
I looked it up and it's for cancer.

LILY
Oh, Rye. I'm sorry. But I'm sure
there's some explanation. Come sit.

SCENE 14: DIAGNOSIS

Lily, DAVID [50s, lawyer], ROSE [50s, doctor], and Rye sit together at a rectangular dinner table. David and Rose look like they get their shoes shined together at the cobbler.

RYE

Yes, then a rat crawled out of the trash bag!

DAVID

You're joking!

RYE

I wish.

Everyone laughs.

RYE (CONT'D)

Well, thank you for having me. I should get going.

ROSE

Of course. Thank you for coming.

RYE

I was actually wondering if I could talk to you about something, Rose?

ROSE

Of course, I'll walk you out.

They get up and walk towards the exit. Rye gives Lily a quick peck.

RYE

I found this in my mom's cabinet.

He hands over the jar.

Rose's expression immediately becomes solemn, like she's trying not to react.

ROSE

What do you want to know?

RYE

I mean, I looked it up. I don't know why my mom would be using this.

ROSE

Honey...

RYE
What? You can tell me, right?
There's not like HIPAA, or
something...

ROSE
Honey, I think this is a talk you
should have with your mom.

RYE
So it's real? Why wouldn't she tell
me?

Rose enters doctor mode.

ROSE
It's not up to me to tell you that,
dear. It could be minor, you'll
need to consult a physician for the
full picture.

RYE
Holy fuck. This can't be real. I'm
gonna go.

Rye grabs his keys and starts to leave.

RYE (CONT'D)
Rose?

ROSE
Yes?

RYE
Please don't tell Lily.

Rose nods.